VERSION FRANÇAISE

Identifying the Top 5 assets and the strategy note

Choosing five, owning the rest: prioritization as an act of governance

Session objectives

By the end of this lab, the MERIDIAN group's Top 5 critical assets is produced, consolidated from the four subsidiary mappings entered in the previous lab, and the "critical assets" subsection is written into the group's strategy note. What is learned here:

- **Justify** the Top 5 exercise by its two official anchor points, and not merely by common sense
- **Consolidate** subsidiary priorities into a group priority, which is an arbitration and not an addition
- **Defend** each line of the Top 5 with an argument that connects rating, dependencies and exposure
- **Articulate** this result with the strategy note opened in session 1, without rewriting anything in it

Prerequisites

- The subsidiary's instance stocked in the previous lab: business assets, supporting assets, security needs. It is the raw material; the Top 5 is EXTRACTED from the map, it is not invented in a meeting.
- The tutorial's relative-position ratings: they now become what they have always been, an instrument of decision.
- The strategy note from session 1, with its "context and target governance" subsection: the session builds on it.

Why five, and why it is an official move

First, defusing the objection that always comes up in committee: "why five? everything is important". The answer rests on two French reference texts, and it is their convergence that gives the exercise its force.

The first is the EBIOS Risk Manager guide, whose vocabulary the tutorial provided: in terms of volume, it states that « 5 à 10 valeurs métier constituent généralement une base suffisante pour orienter la suite de l'étude » ("5 to 10 business assets generally constitute a sufficient base to orient the rest of the study"). In other words, the risk assessment method of sessions 5 and 7 does not need a catalog: it needs a handful of well-chosen business assets, and today's Top 5 is literally its input data. The second is even more operational: in its priority preventive cyber measures published in 2023, ANSSI asks to « établir une liste priorisée des services numériques critiques de l'entité » ("establish a prioritized list of the entity's critical digital services"). The word counts: a PRIORITIZED list, ranked among the five moves the agency judges most urgent for any organization. The Top 5 is therefore neither a schoolroom exercise nor a consultant's flourish: it is a measure recommended by the national authority, and the natural output of the map built in the previous lab.

The profession, for that matter, is no longer mistaken about it: in the CESIN barometer published in 2026, 92 % of companies declare they have identified or are in the process of identifying their critical assets. This figure does not contradict this morning's 81 %, it illuminates it: declaring an identification effort in progress is not having a complete view of one's assets, and the whole gap between intention and a kept inventory lodges there. Identification has become the norm; what still distinguishes mature organizations is the ability to draw from it an owned priority, one that renounces, one that is written and signed. That is exactly this hour's move.

92 %

OF COMPANIES DECLARE THEY HAVE IDENTIFIED OR ARE IDENTIFYING THEIR CRITICAL ASSETS

CESIN barometer published in 2026

81 %

THINK THEY HAVE A COMPLETE VIEW OF THEIR ASSETS: THE WHOLE GAP BETWEEN INTENTION AND A KEPT INVENTORY

Same barometer, seen this morning

What the Top 5 is not, to clear up the classic misunderstanding: it is not the list of the five most expensive servers, nor of the five most fragile systems. It is the list of the assets, in the tutorial's full sense, business assets and the supporting assets that carry them, whose harm would hurt the group's mission the most. Fragility will cross paths with it later, at session 4's audit and then at the risk assessment; today the ranking is by what matters, not by what trembles.

💡 In committee, the Top 5 is always presented with its explicit counterpart: "here are the five, and here is what that means for the rest". A priority that does not say what it deprioritizes will be contested line by line by everyone whose system is not on it.

What a defended candidate looks like: the TRAMONTANE example

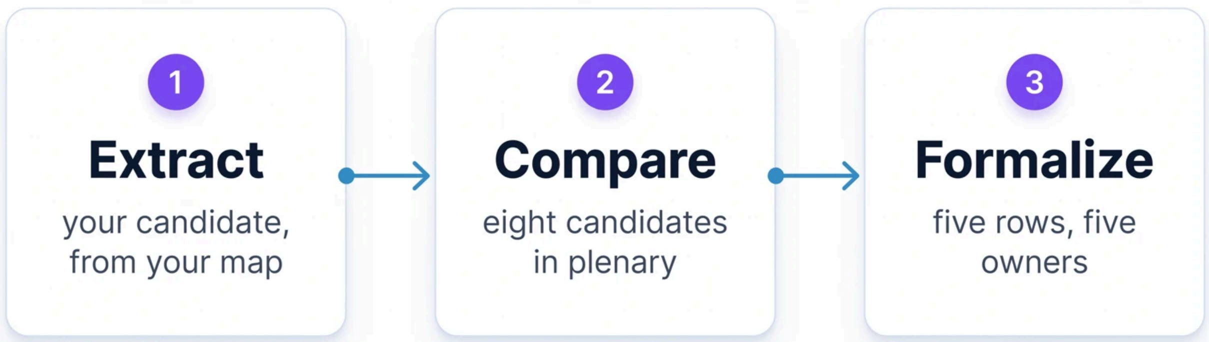
An example outside the pack, to see the shape of a candidacy and of its counterpart. At TRAMONTANE, the fictional online retailer of outdoor equipment that serves as the example outside the pack throughout the module, the CISO extracted three assets from the map, not five, because the company is small and its map knows no more. Each fits in thirty seconds, in the format expected this afternoon: what would be lost, for whom, and why it is worse than the rest.

Asset	What would be lost, for whom	Why it is worse than the rest
Online order taking, carried by the e-commerce site, its database and the hosting provider	The first revenue channel, for the whole company	Two outages in one year have already cost two mornings of sales; no other asset is counted by the hour
Customer and payment data, carried by the customer database and the payment provider	Customer trust and the relationship with the payment provider, for management	A disclosure engages the retailer's liability before the supervisory authority; it is the only harm that is not repaired by restoring a service
Picking and shipping, carried by the warehouse system, the Rivesaltes warehouse and the publisher in remote maintenance	The ability to deliver what is sold, for the warehouse and customer service	A falsified stock sells what one does not have; and the decisive supporting asset, the settings, is known to one person and one provider only

And the counterpart, written under the table: “the head office's office IT, the returns management tool and the corporate website fall under standard treatment; they are not forgotten, they are downgraded, and this sentence is signed”. At MERIDIAN, the same discipline applies at another scale: eight candidacies, four subsidiaries, and dependencies between them that the example does not know.

Exercise: the group's Top 5, by confrontation

The consolidation plays out in three stages, and the second is the most instructive.



1. **Extract** from the subsidiary's instance the candidate for the group's Top 5: the asset, a business asset with its decisive supporting assets, whose harm would hurt the most, grounding the choice in the DICT ratings and not in the intuition of the moment; the assets list, with its inherited security targets, and the "Assets explorer" are enough to spot it. Two groups studied the same subsidiary without consulting each other, and that is the salt of the confrontation to come. The argument takes thirty seconds: what would be lost, for whom, and why it is worse than the rest of the subsidiary.
2. **Confront** in plenary the eight candidacies: each group presents, the others attack. Three arbitration criteria, in this order: business severity (what does the group lose?), inter-subsidiary dependencies (an asset on which two subsidiaries depend weighs more than its isolated equivalent, the emergency supply running thread is the canonical example), and the sector's exposure, because the threat is not uniform: ANSSI's latest panorama, on the incidents brought to its attention in 2025, places education and research at the top of the targeted sectors, about one third, ahead of ministries and local authorities (24 %) and healthcare (10 %). An Éducation subsidiary under-represented in the Top 5 should at the very least spark debate.
3. **Settle** the group's Top 5, five lines, each carrying: the asset, the subsidiary or subsidiaries concerned, the justification in one sentence mobilizing at least two of the three criteria, and the owner who will answer for it, by function, as the map of power of the subsidiary concerned designates them, in direct line with the morning's inventory rule.

Suggested time: 8 minutes of extraction, 12 of confrontation, 5 of formalization. The product: a five-line table, ready for the strategy note, each line of which would survive the question "why that one and not mine?" asked by a disgruntled subsidiary director.

Strategy note (15 minutes)

The module's ritual, third stage: the group's strategy note, opened in session 1 with the "context and target governance" subsection, is enriched today with its second subsection, "critical assets". Half a page at most, within the three-page limit of the complete document, and this cumulative exercise carries 10 points on the module's grading scale.

What the subsection contains: the settled Top 5, as a tight table; the method in two sentences, mapping entered into the group's tool then arbitrated consolidation, because a management team gives its trust to a result whose making it understands; and what this priority commits, the Top 5's counterpart sentence, what is a priority and what is less so. The articulation with session 1 is the most discriminating grading criterion: the "context and target governance" subsection laid down who decides and who arbitrates; the new subsection must lean on it explicitly, attaching the Top 5 to the bodies that will own it, the Group CISO for inter-subsidiary arbitration, the named owners for each asset. A budget argument can usefully close the subsection, and it is verified: for 2025, the CNIL issued nearly 487 million euros in sanctions; prioritizing protections on one's critical assets also means reducing exposure to that kind of bill.

For size and tone, TRAMONTANE's "critical assets" subsection, as its CISO added it to the strategy note, after the "context and target governance" subsection:

> *"In accordance with the governance described in the opening, the CISO has established the map of the retailer's information system and extracted three critical assets from it, settled by the Chief Executive: online order taking, customer and payment data, picking and shipping of orders. Each has a named owner; the detail of supporting assets and ratings is kept in the mapping tool, to which this document refers. This priority commits: protection and audit efforts will bear first on these three assets, the other systems falling under standard treatment. It will be revised at each significant change in the map."*

Four sentences, one reference, one counterpart, one revision clause. MERIDIAN's will have five assets, subsidiaries to name and an inter-subsidiary arbitration to attach to session 1's bodies; the size, though, stays the same.

What the subsection does not contain: the complete list of assets (it lives in the tool, the note refers to it), the detailed ratings (same address), and any promise of an action plan, which belongs to the sessions to come.

And to close the session, the sentence that hands it on: the entered mapping and the settled Top 5 become, as of the next session, the material for the group's choice of framework, where what is regulatorily binding on each subsidiary will have to be qualified, and the yardstick chosen against which everything inventoried today will be evaluated.

Answer keys and assessment criteria — cliquer pour révéler